"Telephone Conversation" is a satirical poem written by Wole Soyinka, a Nigerian playwright and poet. The poem was published in 1963 and addresses the theme of racism and prejudice. Through a telephone conversation between an African man and a landlady, the poet exposes the absurdity and irrationality of racial discrimination prevalent during that time.

The poem comprises two main characters: the African man, who is the speaker of the poem, and the landlady on the other end of the telephone line.

The poem begins with the speaker seeking accommodation, and the landlady's initial response is polite and business-like. However, as soon as she asks about the speaker's race, her demeanor changes dramatically. She asks whether he is "dark or very light" and he hesitates, sensing her prejudice.

The landlady's racism becomes evident when she asks if he is "West African or East African," assuming that Africans can only be categorized based on their ethnicity. The poem highlights the absurdity of such racial categorization, emphasizing how the landlady is reducing the speaker to a mere stereotype.

The African man responds sarcastically and cleverly, stating that he is "African," leading the landlady to ask an offensive question, "How dark?" The speaker replies with a witty remark, describing his complexion as "West African sepia." The use of the word "sepia" is significant as it not only adds an element of humor but also refers to the color of old photographs, subtly implying that his skin color should not be a matter of concern or discrimination.

As the conversation progresses, the landlady becomes more agitated, suggesting that the speaker might be "darker than the typical 'dark'" African. She then uses an offensive racial epithet, "damn dark," to describe his skin color. The poet uses this language to expose the harsh reality of racial prejudice faced by many Africans during that period.

Throughout the conversation, the African man maintains his composure and intelligence, which contrasts sharply with the landlady's ignorance and bigotry. The poem portrays the speaker as an individual who has to navigate a world where he is constantly judged and discriminated against based on his race, which is entirely beyond his control.

The final lines of the poem reveal the speaker's triumph over the landlady's racism. He tells her that he will not be living in her accommodation, leaving

her to face the consequences of her prejudice. The poem ends on a powerful note, illustrating the silent victory of the African man over the landlady's bigotry.

In "Telephone Conversation," Wole Soyinka effectively uses humor, irony, and wit to shed light on the absurdity of racial discrimination and the resilience of those who face it. The poem continues to be relevant, reminding readers of the importance of confronting and challenging prejudices in society.

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